

RESIN

FADE IN:

EXT. POWHATAN RESERVATION – SHACK – NIGHT

Moonlight pours through gaps in old wooden boards.

Inside, a small fire burns in a metal drum.

A homemade still sits in the corner, quietly working.

Mason jars pass hand to hand.

CHRISTOPHER (24) sits on an overturned crate, calm, observant.

JOSHUA (23) laughs too loudly at everything.

RYAN (22) leans against a wall, half-listening.

BRANDON (21) is already halfway into a joke no one asked for.

A hemp joint is passed around.

The room fills with smoke and low laughter.

JOSHUA

This stuff hits different when the moon's watching.

BRANDON

The moon's always watching, man.

CHRISTOPHER

That's not comforting.

They laugh.

A beat of silence settles again.

Not awkward. Familiar.

RYAN

You ever think about leaving?

Joshua shrugs immediately.

JOSHUA

Leave and go where?

BRANDON

Same place, just with more traffic.

More laughter.

Christopher doesn't laugh right away.

He looks at the jar in his hand.

CHRISTOPHER

People always think "getting out"
fixes something.

A pause.

No one interrupts him.

CHRISTOPHER (CONT'D)

You take yourself with you.

That lands differently.

The room quiets for a second longer than usual.

JOSHUA

That sounded like a fortune cookie.

CHRISTOPHER

Probably was.

They laugh again, tension broken.

EXT. SHACK – CONTINUOUS

The group steps outside for air.

Crickets loud.

Moon high.

The same jar keeps moving hand to hand.

BRANDON

I swear this place makes time move weird.

RYAN

It doesn't move weird. We just don't do anything with it.

Joshua points out toward the dark road.

JOSHUA

We doing anything tonight or just philosophizing?

Christopher smiles slightly.

CHRISTOPHER

We can go ride.

That gets everyone's attention.

Brandon grins.

BRANDON

Now you're talking.

EXT. DIRT ROAD – LATER

Old pickup truck rattling over gravel.

Music low, bass shaking the cab.

Inside:

Laughter again.

Easy, constant.

Noah-like stillness between jokes.

EXT. BACK TRAILS – NIGHT

The truck is parked.

Four silhouettes move off into darkness.

Headlights from distant roads flicker through trees.

They drink.

They smoke.

They talk over each other.

JOSHUA

If I win the next race, I'm not paying for anything for a week.

BRANDON

You don't pay for anything anyway.

JOSHUA

Exactly. Upgrade.

They laugh.

Christopher watches them for a moment.

Not distant. Just thinking.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. BACK TRAILS – NIGHT – CONTINUOUS

Four silhouettes lean against the hood of the truck.

Headlights from passing roads flicker through distant trees.

A bottle of moonshine moves hand to hand.

A hemp joint burns low between them.

This is not a party.

It's routine.

BRANDON

I'm telling you, if I had money,
I'd leave tomorrow.

JOSHUA

You'd come back in a week.

BRANDON

No I wouldn't.

RYAN

You don't even leave the county when you're sober.

Brandon points at Ryan like that's unfair.

BRANDON

That's because I'm budgeting.

Joshua laughs.

JOSHUA

Budgeting what? Time?

Ryan takes a sip from the jar, hands it off.

RYAN

There's nothing out there that's different.

That quiets them for a second.

Christopher finally speaks.

CHRISTOPHER

It's not that it's different.

He looks out into the trees.

CHRISTOPHER (CONT'D)

It's that we'd still be us.

A beat.

Brandon nods like he understands and doesn't like it.

BRANDON

That's depressing.

JOSHUA

That's life.

They laugh again.

The moment passes like smoke.

EXT. BACK TRAILS – LATER

The group sits on the tailgate now.

Shoes dangling.

Music from a phone speaker crackling out old rap and country mixed together.

No one agrees on the playlist.

No one changes it.

JOSHUA

Remember when we thought we were gonna do something big?

BRANDON

We are doing something big.

RYAN

Like what?

BRANDON

Surviving adulthood.

Joshua raises the jar like it's a trophy.

JOSHUA

I'm crushing it.

They all laugh.

Christopher watches them again.

Same look as before.

Not sadness.

Just awareness.

EXT. DIRT ROAD – MOMENTS LATER

The truck rolls slow now.

Windows down.

Wind cutting through laughter.

They pass small houses with porch lights on.

Some TVs flicker through windows.

Life happening in pieces.

RYAN

My dad still thinks I'm gonna

get a real job.

BRANDON

You could.

RYAN

Doing what?

BRANDON

Something with benefits.

That gets a laugh.

Even Ryan smiles a little.

JOSHUA

I tried working at that warehouse one summer.

CHRISTOPHER

How long did it last?

JOSHUA

Three days.

BRANDON

That's basically retirement.

They pass the reservation sign.

No one comments on it.

They don't need to.

EXT. OLD GAS STATION – NIGHT

Fluorescent lights buzz.

Truck parked crooked.

They pile out.

Same routine, different night.

Snacks they can barely afford.

Cheap drinks.

Familiar faces inside wave without looking up from phones.

CLERK behind the counter barely reacts.

He's seen all of them before.

CLERK

Same trouble as always?

JOSHUA

Worse.

CLERK

That's not possible.

Joshua grins.

JOSHUA

Watch us.

EXT. PARKING LOT – CONTINUOUS

They lean against the truck.

Wind pushing through empty space around them.

Boredom sits between conversations like another person.

BRANDON

We should do something tonight.

RYAN

We are doing something.

BRANDON

No, like... actually do something.

JOSHUA

We could race.

That lands immediately.

CHRISTOPHER

Route 60?

Joshua nods.

Brandon already smiling.

Ryan shrugs like he was going to say yes anyway.

BRANDON

That's something.

Christopher finishes his drink.

CHRISTOPHER

Yeah.

A beat.

CHRISTOPHER (CONT'D)

That's something.

They get back in the truck.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. BAR PARKING LOT – NIGHT

A gravel lot full of trucks.

Neon sign flickering: "THE RIDGE BAR"

Country music leaking through the walls.

The group steps out of the truck.

Same energy. Slightly louder now.

Same boredom underneath it.

BRANDON

This place smells like regret.

JOSHUA

That's just alcohol and bad decisions.

RYAN

So... regret.

They head inside.

INT. BAR – CONTINUOUS

Dim lighting.

Pool tables.

Cheap beer.

Laughter from people who've known each other too long.

The group blends in immediately.

Not outsiders.

Not insiders.

Just present.

Christopher drops quarters on the pool table.

CHRISTOPHER

Winner stays.

JOSHUA

Winner buys drinks.

RYAN

Winner probably still leaves broke.

Brandon is already scanning the room.

BRANDON

Alright. I'm gonna do something productive.

JOSHUA

You've never done that in your life.

Brandon ignores him and walks off.

ANGLE ON: BAR COUNTER

Brandon tries a confident lean.

Fails slightly.

A WOMAN laughs at something he says.

He thinks that's a good sign.

BACK TO POOL TABLE

Christopher lines up a shot.

Joshua distracts him immediately.

JOSHUA

If I make this ball, I'm basically
legally a professional athlete.

RYAN

That's not how laws work.

Joshua shoots anyway. Misses badly.

No one is surprised.

INT. BAR – LATER

Music louder now.

Pool game abandoned halfway through.

Everyone has a drink they didn't fully pay attention to acquiring.

Brandon returns, slightly victorious.

BRANDON

I made a connection.

JOSHUA

With who? The bartender's pity?

BRANDON

With society.

Ryan shakes his head.

RYAN

That doesn't sound real.

Christopher watches the room.

Not focused on anything.

Just taking it in.

CHRISTOPHER

We should probably head out soon.

JOSHUA

Why? We just got here.

CHRISTOPHER

That's why.

A beat.

Brandon leans in.

BRANDON

Route 60 is tonight, right?

Joshua smiles immediately.

JOSHUA

Always.

CUT TO:

EXT. HIGHWAY EDGE – NIGHT

Two trucks parked side by side.

Headlights cutting into darkness.

A small crowd of friends gathered on the shoulder.

Phones out.

Laughter bouncing off empty road.

Christopher's truck idles.

Joshua is already halfway out the window.

JOSHUA

Nobody chickens out this time!

RYAN

Somebody always chickens out.

Brandon is hyped.

BRANDON

I'm not losing tonight.

Christopher says nothing.

Just grips the wheel.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – CONTINUOUS

Two trucks line up.

Engines rev.

Headlights stare forward like eyes.

A PHONE COUNTDOWN.

CROWD

Three...

Two...

One!

TIRES SCREAM.

Both trucks launch forward.

INT. CHRISTOPHER'S TRUCK – MOVING – NIGHT

Wind shaking everything.

Joshua yelling.

Brandon laughing like it's joy or fear or both.

Ryan holding onto the dashboard.

JOSHUA
GO—GO—GO—

Christopher steady.

Focused.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – CONTINUOUS

The trucks race through darkness.

No rules except speed.

Brandon leans out the window, screaming.

BRANDON
THIS IS WHAT I'M TALKING ABOUT!

Christopher's truck pulls slightly ahead.

INT. TRUCK – CONTINUOUS

Ryan notices.

RYAN
We're ahead.

Christopher doesn't respond.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – FINISH POINT – NIGHT

The trucks slow.

Dust and gravel settling.

Cheering erupts from the small crowd.

Joshua throws his arms up.

JOSHUA
THAT'S WHAT I'M TALKING ABOUT!

Brandon jumps out immediately.

BRANDON
We won that!

Ryan steps out slower.

Watching the road like it's still moving.

Christopher finally exits the truck.

Quiet.

He looks back at the empty stretch of highway.

A long beat.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. BRANDON'S TRUCK – MORNING

Sunlight punches through cracked windshield glass.

Empty bottles in cup holders.

Fast food wrappers everywhere.

The group is half-asleep in and around the truck.

RYAN sits on the ground, hoodie over his head.

JOSHUA is face-down in the back seat.

BRANDON is leaning against the hood, sunglasses still on.

CHRISTOPHER is already awake.

Always first.

A GIRL (early 20s) sits on the tailgate, silent, scrolling her phone.

Another GIRL nearby ties her shoes, not saying much.

No drama.

Just distance.

BRANDON

I feel like I got hit by a small government.

JOSHUA

(muffled)

I can taste noise.

Ryan groans.

RYAN

Why do we keep doing this?

Christopher hands Joshua a bottle of water.

CHRISTOPHER

Because there's nothing else to do.

A beat.

Brandon nods like that's acceptable.

EXT. DIRT LOT – LATER

The group loads into old dirt bikes.

Helmets cracked, mismatched gear.

Engines cough to life.

BRANDON

Whoever wins gets bragging rights.

JOSHUA

I already have those.

RYAN

You can't win those.

Christopher tightens his helmet strap.

He looks over at them.

Quiet confidence.

EXT. TRAILS – DAY

Dust and trees.

Dirt bikes tearing through narrow paths.

The sound of engines fills everything.

The group is alive again.

Not thinking.

Just moving.

JOSHUA (O.S.)

I'm coming for all of you!

BRANDON (O.S.)

You couldn't catch a cold!

They weave through trees.

Laughing, yelling.

EXT. CLEARING – LATE DAY

They stop.

Bikes idling.

Dust settling around them.

The GIRLS from earlier are here now too, sitting on rocks and logs.

No explanation needed.

Just part of the orbit of the day.

Everyone is passing a hemp joint around.

Loose circle.

No structure.

GIRL #1

You guys always do this?

BRANDON

Only when we're alive.

She laughs.

Not impressed. Not uninterested. Just present.

Ryan sits slightly apart.

Watching the trees more than the people.

RYAN

This is gonna catch up to us one day.

Joshua leans back, relaxed.

JOSHUA

Everything catches up eventually.

Christopher watches the group.

Same expression as always.

Like he's memorizing the moment instead of living inside it.

CHRISTOPHER

Not today though.

A beat.

They pass the joint again.

EXT. TRAIL EDGE – LATER

Sun lowering.

Everyone packing up slowly.

Bikes cooling down.

BRANDON

Same thing tomorrow?

JOSHUA

Same thing forever.

Ryan doesn't laugh.

Just looks down the trail.

RYAN

Something moved back there.

BRANDON

It's called nature.

Ryan shakes his head slightly.

RYAN

No. Like... something watching.

Joshua groans.

JOSHUA
Not this again.

Christopher looks toward the trees.

Nothing visible.

Just stillness.

He shrugs it off.

CHRISTOPHER
Probably a fox or something.

They all laugh lightly.

It passes.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS – NIGHT (LATER)

Same group.

Same spot as before.

Moonshine jar.

Hemp smoke.

Familiar rhythm.

They're walking now.

Talking over each other.

BRANDON

I swear if I ever get bit by something,
I'm suing the entire forest.

JOSHUA

You can't sue nature.

BRANDON

Watch me.

A RUSTLE in the trees.

Everyone slows.

RYAN

There.

A FOX steps out.

Too fast.

Too jittery.

Same one.

It circles them.

Silence falls.

JOSHUA

Why is it back?

The fox lunges.

Chaos.

It bites BRANDON'S leg.

BRANDON
OH—WHAT THE—

He falls back into the dirt, flailing.

Joshua bursts out laughing immediately.

JOSHUA
IT GOT YOU AGAIN!

Christopher kicks the fox away instinctively.

It releases and bolts into the trees.

Silence.

Brandon sits up, stunned.

Then laughs.

BRANDON
I just got bullied by a forest animal.

Ryan stares at the bite.

RYAN

That's worse than last time.

Christopher looks down at the wound.

A beat.

He unscrews the moonshine jar.

Brandon sees it.

BRANDON

No—don't—

Christopher pours it onto the bite.

BRANDON SCREAMS.

BRANDON (CONT'D)

WHY IS THAT OUR MEDICAL SYSTEM?!?

Joshua is laughing so hard he's bent over.

JOSHUA

THAT FOX HAS PERSONAL BEEF WITH YOU!

Brandon is laughing too now.

Pain mixed with disbelief.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. WOODS – NIGHT – CONTINUOUS

The group walks back through the trees.

Same rhythm.

Same laughter.

Brandon is still talking through pain.

BRANDON

I'm telling you, that fox is plotting on me.

JOSHUA

You're not that important.

BRANDON

That's what someone being plotted on would say.

Ryan glances back once.

Nothing there.

Still uneasy.

RYAN

It didn't act normal.

CHRISTOPHER

Animals don't act normal.

RYAN

That one didn't act like an animal.

Joshua waves it off.

JOSHUA

It's a fox. It's basically a raccoon with anger issues.

Brandon limps slightly.

Still laughing.

BRANDON

I'm fine. It barely even got me.

Christopher looks at the bite again.

A small pause.

CHRISTOPHER

You should probably get that checked.

Brandon laughs immediately.

BRANDON

By who? The same guy that charged me
twenty bucks for Tylenol last time?

Joshua claps him on the back.

JOSHUA

Moonshine's cheaper medicine.

Christopher doesn't argue.

Just closes the jar.

EXT. SHACK AREA – LATER NIGHT

The group returns.

Fire is low now.

Everything slower.

More tired.

People scatter—leaning against trees, sitting on logs, checking phones.

The GIRLS from earlier are gone.

No explanation.

Just absence.

Brandon sits on a log.

Pulls his pant leg slightly.

The bite mark is visible.

Small.

Nothing dramatic.

He stares at it like it's already boring.

BRANDON

It's nothing.

Ryan looks at it longer than anyone else.

RYAN

It broke skin.

BRANDON

So does everything out here.

Joshua tosses a rock into the darkness.

JOSHUA

If you turn into a zombie, I'm not hanging out with you anymore.

BRANDON

Deal.

They laugh.

Christopher sits apart from them slightly.

Watching.

Not alarmed.

Just observant.

He looks toward the woods again.

Nothing.

EXT. SHACK – LATER

The night winds down.

Conversation fades into silence.

Joshua is half asleep.

Ryan is staring at the fire.

Brandon is leaning back, relaxed again.

Christopher is still awake.

The jar is nearly empty.

RYAN
We should head out.

No one moves immediately.

A beat.

Then slowly:

They start gathering things.

EXT. ROAD – NIGHT

The truck pulls away.

Headlights disappear down the dirt road.

Silence returns to the woods.

CUT TO:

EXT. RESERVATION – VARIOUS – MONTAGE

— Morning light over empty roads

— Brandon walking normally, laughing with Joshua

— Christopher fixing something on the truck

— Ryan working, distracted, glancing at his phone

— Brandon ignoring the bite mark while moving through his day

— A fox in the distance once, gone before it's clear

— Life continuing exactly as before

No one mentions it.

CUT TO:

EXT. GAS STATION – DAY

The group gathers again like nothing happened.

Snacks.

Cheap drinks.

Same clerk.

CLERK
You guys look tired.

JOSHUA
That's called living.

Brandon laughs too hard.

His leg shifts slightly.

He winces for half a second.

No one notices.

CUT TO:

EXT. DIRT ROAD – SUNSET

Truck idling.

Same crew.

Same energy rebuilding itself.

Joshua leans out the window.

JOSHUA

Tonight we're racing again?

Brandon grins.

BRANDON

Always.

Ryan doesn't argue anymore.

Christopher starts the truck.

CHRISTOPHER

Yeah.

A beat.

He drives.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – NIGHT (SETUP)

The road stretches ahead.

Empty.

Waiting.

Headlights appear in the distance.

Two trucks line up again.

The group gathers at the edge of the road.

Joshua excited already.

JOSHUA
Nobody's losing tonight!

Brandon laughs.

BRANDON
I already lost today, so I'm good.

Ryan looks at the road.

Christopher grips the wheel.

Quiet.

Focused.

A phone COUNTDOWN starts again.

CROWD

Three...

Two...

One...

ENGINES ROAR.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – NIGHT

Two trucks idle side by side.

Headlights cut through darkness.

A small crowd gathers on the shoulder again.

Same people. Same ritual.

Different night.

INT. CHRISTOPHER'S TRUCK – NIGHT

Christopher grips the wheel.

Focused.

Joshua is already hyped in the passenger seat.

Ryan sits behind them, quiet.

Brandon is in the back, leg slightly extended.

JOSHUA

Nobody loses tonight. I mean it.

RYAN

That's statistically impossible.

BRANDON

Let him believe in miracles.

Joshua laughs and leans out the window.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – CONTINUOUS

PHONE COUNTDOWN.

CROWD

Three...

Two...

One!

ENGINES ROAR.

The trucks launch forward.

INT. TRUCK – MOVING – NIGHT

Wind shakes everything.

Joshua is yelling.

Brandon is laughing too hard again.

Ryan watches the road, calm and alert.

Christopher doesn't blink.

JOSHUA
COME ON—COME ON—

Brandon shifts in the back.

Winces.

Just a flicker.

Ryan notices.

RYAN
You alright?

BRANDON
Yeah. It's nothing.

Christopher hears it and doesn't look back.

EXT. ROUTE 60 – CONTINUOUS

The race stretches out.

Lights blur.

Speed builds.

Christopher's truck edges ahead again.

INT. TRUCK – CONTINUOUS

Joshua is losing his mind.

JOSHUA
WE GOT IT—WE GOT IT—

Ryan looks back at Brandon again.

Brandon's leg is now angled awkwardly.

RYAN
Dude. Seriously.

BRANDON
It's just sore.

He forces a grin.

Christopher finally speaks, eyes still forward.

CHRISTOPHER
After this, go get it checked.

Brandon laughs.

BRANDON
You sound like my mom.

Joshua turns around.

JOSHUA
Your mom's right though.

Brandon flips him off weakly.

EXT. FINISH POINT – NIGHT

The trucks slow.

Crowd erupts.

Joshua jumps out first.

JOSHUA
THAT'S WHAT I'M TALKING ABOUT!

Brandon exits slower.

He's still laughing.

and it's thinner now.

Ryan notices again.

Doesn't say anything.

Christopher looks down the empty highway.

Quiet again.

CUT TO:

EXT. RESERVATION ROAD – NIGHT

Truck driving slow now.

Music low.

No celebration left.

Brandon leans his head back.

BRANDON
I think I pulled something.

JOSHUA
From winning?

BRANDON
From existing.

No one laughs as hard this time.

CUT TO:

EXT. GAS STATION – NIGHT

Fluorescent lights buzz.

Same clerk.

Same routine.

Brandon limps slightly now.

The CLERK notices.

CLERK
You alright?

BRANDON
Yeah. Just tired.

Joshua grabs snacks.

Ryan watches Brandon without staring directly.

Christopher pays.

CLERK

You guys always look like this after dark.

JOSHUA

That's just our brand.

CUT TO:

EXT. SHACK AREA – NIGHT

Fire again.

Moonshine again.

Hemp again.

Energy is lower.

More scattered.

Brandon sits down slowly.

A little too carefully.

Ryan sits next to him.

RYAN

Let me see it.

BRANDON
It's fine.

RYAN
Just let me see.

Brandon hesitates.

Then pulls up his pant leg.

The bite is slightly worse.

Redder.

Angrier looking.

Ryan's expression changes slightly.

RYAN (CONT'D)
That wasn't like that yesterday.

BRANDON
It was.

Ryan shakes his head.

RYAN
No.

Joshua leans in.

JOSHUA

It looks like it's getting mad.

Brandon laughs it off.

BRANDON

Everything looks mad out here.

Christopher looks at it longer than before.

CHRISTOPHER

You ever think maybe that fox
wasn't just a fox?

Joshua laughs immediately.

JOSHUA

Here we go.

Christopher doesn't smile.

CHRISTOPHER

I'm serious.

A beat.

Ryan stands slightly.

RYAN

You should go to a clinic.

Brandon pulls his leg back down.

BRANDON
I'll go tomorrow.

Joshua throws a log into the fire.

JOSHUA
That's the universal lie.

They laugh.

It doesn't fully land anymore.

CUT TO:

EXT. BRIDGE OVER CREEK – NIGHT

Brandon sits alone briefly.

Not dramatic.

Just apart.

Water below.

Dark and moving.

Ryan approaches.

RYAN
I'm not trying to be annoying.

BRANDON

You're doing great at it.

Ryan ignores that.

RYAN

I've seen infections before.

That doesn't look normal.

Brandon finally stops joking for a second.

BRANDON

Nothing out here is normal.

A beat.

Ryan nods slightly.

Silence.

Brandon stands.

BRANDON

I'm fine.

He walks back toward the others.

Ryan watches him go.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. HOSPITAL – ER – NIGHT

Bright fluorescent lights.

Too clean.

Too loud.

BRANDON lies in a hospital bed.

Sweat on his forehead.

Eyes unfocused.

CHRISTOPHER, JOSHUA, and RYAN stand nearby.

Quiet now.

No jokes.

A DOCTOR (40s) stands at the foot of the bed.

Chart in hand.

Careful tone.

DOCTOR

When did the bite occur?

A long beat.

Ryan answers first.

RYAN

About a month ago.

The doctor nods slowly.

Like he already knows.

DOCTOR

And when did symptoms start?

Christopher looks at Brandon.

Brandon shifts in the bed.

Uncomfortable.

CHRISTOPHER

A few days ago.

The doctor exhales slightly through his nose.

Not surprise.

Confirmation.

DOCTOR

Nausea. Anxiety. Agitation.
Difficulty sleeping?

Ryan nods immediately.

RYAN

Yeah.

The doctor closes the chart halfway.

DOCTOR
Has he had any hydrophobia?
Trouble swallowing liquids?

Joshua laughs once, nervously, then stops himself.

JOSHUA
He said water felt weird yesterday.

Silence sharpens.

The doctor looks at them now more directly.

DOCTOR
I need to be very clear with you.

A pause.

Brandon shifts in the bed again.

Twitching slightly.

DOCTOR (CONT'D)
Once neurological symptoms begin,
rabies is almost always fatal.

The word lands.

FATAL.

No one speaks immediately.

Ryan looks at Brandon.

Then away.

Christopher doesn't move.

Joshua swallows.

JOSHUA

There's... treatment though, right?

The doctor hesitates.

That hesitation answers everything.

DOCTOR

At this stage, treatment is supportive care only.

Silence.

Brandon laughs suddenly.

Not fully controlled.

BRANDON

I'm fine.

He tries to sit up.

Can't quite coordinate it.

BRANDON (CONT'D)

It's just like... fever or something.

Ryan steps closer.

RYAN

Dude.

Brandon looks at him.

Eyes unfocused.

BRANDON

I said I'm fine.

Christopher finally speaks.

CHRISTOPHER

It was that fox.

No one argues.

Because there's nothing left to argue.

The doctor steps back slightly.

DOCTOR

We're going to keep him comfortable.
That's the priority now.

Joshua shakes his head.

JOSHUA

No. No, that's not—
that's not how this goes.

No one responds.

Joshua looks at Brandon.

Brandon is staring at the ceiling now.

Breathing uneven.

Like he's listening to something no one else can hear.

Ryan sits down slowly in the corner chair.

Like his legs stopped working.

Christopher stays standing.

Watching Brandon.

Still.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM – LATER

Lights dimmer now.

Machines softly beeping.

Brandon is worse.

Sweating.

Twitching.

Trying to speak and stopping halfway.

Joshua sits at the edge of the room now.

Silent for once.

Ryan hasn't moved.

Christopher stands closest to the bed.

Brandon suddenly grips the sheet.

Hard.

BRANDON
(barely)
It's loud.

RYAN
What's loud?

Brandon shakes his head.

Can't explain it.

BRANDON
Everything.

A beat.

He starts breathing faster.

Joshua stands.

JOSHUA
Hey—hey, you're okay.

And he doesn't believe it.

Brandon's eyes dart around the room.

Not focused on them anymore.

BRANDON
I can't—

He stops.

Jaw tight.

Swallowing is difficult.

The doctor enters quietly from outside the frame.

He already knows what he's walking into.

Christopher looks at him.

A silent question.

The doctor doesn't answer it.

Just lowers his gaze slightly.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. RESERVATION – SHACK – NIGHT

Moonlight again.

Same shack.

Same firepit.

Three chairs around the fire.

CHRISTOPHER.

JOSHUA.

RYAN.

One chair is missing.

No one speaks for a long time.

The fire crackles louder than it should.

Joshua sits in his funeral clothes.

Tie loosened.

Shirt wrinkled.

Ryan hasn't changed out of his jacket.

Still standing slightly like he forgot how to sit comfortably in the world.

Christopher stares into the fire.

Silence stretches.

No one tries to fill it anymore.

A long beat.

Joshua finally exhales.

JOSHUA

I keep thinking he's gonna walk up
from the road late like always.

No response.

Ryan nods once.

Barely.

RYAN

Yeah.

Christopher looks toward the tree line.

Same place everything started.

CHRISTOPHER
We all saw it.

A beat.

No one corrects him.

No one needs to.

Joshua picks up a small stone.

Turns it in his hand.

JOSHUA
It didn't even feel real.

Ryan finally sits down.

RYAN
It was real.

Silence again.

Longer this time.

The fire shifts in the wind.

Christopher leans forward slightly.

CHRISTOPHER
We're still here.

Joshua lets out something between a laugh and nothing at all.

JOSHUA
Yeah.

A beat.

JOSHUA (CONT'D)
That's the problem.

They sit.

The fire burns down slowly.

No music.

No jokes.

No movement that matters.

Just time passing.

CUT TO:

EXT. SHACK – LATER NIGHT

The fire is lower now.

The three of them remain.

No one has gotten up.

No one wants to be the first to leave.

The wind moves through the trees.

Somewhere far off, a dog barks.

Life continues.

CUT TO BLACK.

FINAL IMAGE:

EXT. RESERVATION – DAWN

The shack is empty.

Cold ash in the firepit.

Footprints from last night already fading in the dirt.

The road beyond it is active again.

Cars passing.

People going somewhere.

The world does not pause.

FADE OUT.